

Website Migration Plan

WordPress / BlueHost → Hugo + Cloudflare Pages

Prepared for [Institution]

August 2026

Overview

This plan moves the [Institution] website off WordPress/BlueHost onto a modern, low-maintenance, institution-owned stack: **content in Git, built by Hugo, hosted on Cloudflare Pages, edited through a friendly web CMS (Sveltia).**

A working proof-of-concept already exists and is deployed, so this is a *migration*, not an experiment. The architecture, editor workflow, theming, and media embedding are all proven.

Goals

- **Eliminate maintenance overhead:** no database, no plugins, no security patch treadmill.
- **Durability:** content lives as plain text in Git; portable and re-hostable in an afternoon if any vendor changes.
- **Cost control:** at or below current BlueHost/WordPress spend (see the *Hosting & Platform Tiers* document).
- **Editor-friendly:** a non-technical editor can update content, images, and theme without touching code.
- **Institution ownership:** all accounts and content owned by [Institution], not any individual.

Guiding principles

- **Source is truth:** the Git repository is the single, versioned source; it is also the backup.
 - **Static by default:** near-zero attack surface.
 - **No lock-in:** Markdown + Hugo are open and portable.
 - **Reversible cutover:** DNS change is the only irreversible-feeling step, and it rolls back by repointing DNS.
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Phases

Each phase lists its tasks, the owner, a rough effort estimate, and the exit criteria (the “done” checkpoint) that gates the next phase.

Phase 0: Preparation & inventory

Owner: Administrator · **Effort:** ~0.5–1 day

- Inventory every page/URL on the current site (crawl with `wget --mirror` or HTTrack).
- Record the existing URL structure (to preserve or redirect for SEO).
- Collect all assets (images, documents) and the third-party donate snippet.
- **Verify the domain's actual registrar via WHOIS** and locate its login. Note: a ~\$224/yr bill from “American Domain Services” is far above market and may be a renewal solicitation rather than the real registrar. Confirm before paying.

Exit criteria: complete page list, asset archive, URL map, and confirmed registrar access.

Phase 1: Build & theme

Owner: Administrator · **Effort:** mostly complete (POC)

- The Hugo site, “Modern Heritage” theme, editor configuration, and media embedding are built and proven in the POC.
- Remaining: adapt page structure/content model to the real site's needs.

Exit criteria: local build renders the real site's page set cleanly.

Phase 2: Institution accounts & ownership

Owner: Administrator · **Effort:** ~0.5 day

- Create the **GitHub Organization** owned by [Institution] (not a personal account); add a **second owner** to avoid single-person lock-in.
- Apply for **GitHub for Nonprofits** (free Team plan for verified 501(c)(3)s).
- Create the **Cloudflare account** under an institutional/role email.
- Decide the tier (see *Hosting & Platform Tiers*).

Exit criteria: org + repo created, Cloudflare account ready, ownership documented.

Phase 3: Content migration

Owner: Administrator (+ editor for review) · **Effort:** ~1–3 days (scales with page count)

- Convert each page's content to Markdown in the repo.
- Move images into the media library; add captions/attribution where required.
- Wire global values (footer/contact, donate copy) into Site Settings.
- Insert the real donate snippet and any video embeds.

Exit criteria: all real content present; local build matches intended site.

Phase 4: Staging review & sign-off

Owner: Editor + stakeholders · **Effort:** ~2–5 days (calendar, for review)

- Deploy to the Cloudflare preview/* .pages.dev URL.
- Stakeholders review content, links, images, mobile layout, accessibility.

- Editor does a trial edit end-to-end (login → change → publish).

Exit criteria: written stakeholder sign-off on the staged site.

Phase 5: Domain & DNS cutover

Owner: Administrator · **Effort:** ~0.5 day + monitoring

- Move the domain's DNS to Cloudflare (update nameservers at the registrar).
- **Transfer the domain registration to an at-cost registrar** (Cloudflare Registrar, ~\$8.50/yr for .org): unlock the domain at the current registrar, obtain the EPP/auth code, and initiate the transfer. This ends the ~\$224/yr bill and consolidates DNS + registration in one place.
- Add the custom domain in Cloudflare Pages (automatic, free SSL).
- Add redirects (`_redirects`) for any changed URLs to preserve SEO.
- **Lower the DNS TTL 24h ahead**, cut over, and monitor.

Exit criteria: production domain serves the new site over HTTPS; redirects verified; no broken links.

Phase 6: Decommission

Owner: Administrator · **Effort:** ~0.5 day

- Run a verification window (≈1 week) with the new site live.
- Export a final backup of the old WordPress site for the archive.
- Cancel BlueHost/WordPress hosting.
- Hand the editor their login and the *Editing Guide*.

Exit criteria: old hosting cancelled; editor onboarded; archive stored.

Rollback strategy

- **Before cutover:** the old site remains untouched and live; the new site is only on the preview URL. Zero risk.
 - **At cutover:** the only real change is DNS. If anything is wrong, repoint DNS back to BlueHost. Propagation is fast because the TTL was lowered in advance.
 - **After cutover:** every prior version is recoverable via Git (`git checkout`); Cloudflare keeps prior deployments that can be re-promoted instantly.
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Risks & mitigations

Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation
Broken inbound links / lost SEO	Medium	URL map in Phase 0; <code>_redirects</code> in Phase 5

Risk	Likelihood	Mitigation
Editor struggles with the CMS	Low	<i>Editing Guide</i> + a 30-min walkthrough
DNS cutover confusion	Low	Lower TTL ahead; rollback = repoint DNS
Vendor change (host/CMS)	Low	Content is portable Markdown in Git
Single-person dependency	Medium	Institution-owned org + second owner

Roles

Role	Responsibility
Administrator	Setup, migration, cutover, ongoing technical care (minimal)
Editor(s)	Day-to-day content updates via the CMS
Stakeholders / board	Review and sign-off at Phase 4; tier decision

Rough timeline

A small informational site ($\approx$ 6–15 pages) is realistically a **1–2 week** elapsed effort, most of which is content review and stakeholder sign-off. The technical work is a few days. The POC has already retired the highest-risk unknowns.